Final Presentation

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Introduction to the book

"Jonathan Wolff, *An Introduction to Moral Philosophy*, 3rd Edition."

The structure of ethics is expanded. It clearly distinguishes between:

Meta-ethics : What is morality itself ?

Normative ethics : What is correct behavior ?

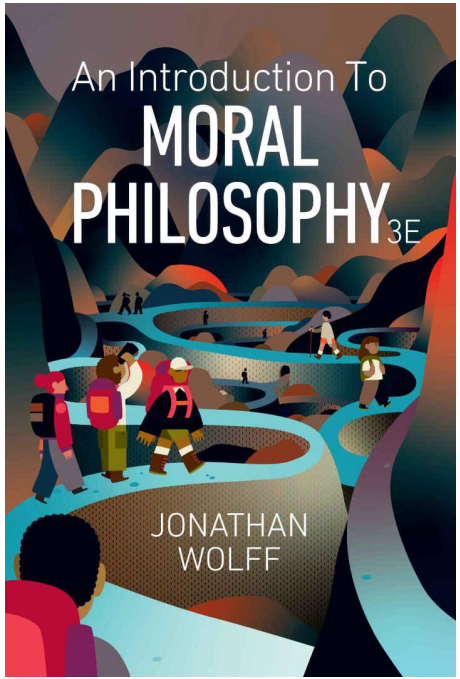
Applied ethics: Specific practical problems

More topics on: gender ethics, race ethics, social justice, public policy

More real-world examples relevant about current society:

cultural practices including polygamy, child marriage

LGBTQ+



Autonomous driving technology

How to make people accept this technology ethically and morally?

Egoism

Utilitarianism

Social Contract Theory

Egoism

Main idea: egoism says an action is right if it promotes one’s own self-interest.

Egoism asks: Does autonomous driving align with the self-interest of those involved?

For manufacturers:

- larger markets,
- more data,
- stronger technological advantage.

For users:

- less driving fatigue,
- more convenience,
- potentially safer travel.

→ It promotes people's personal interests.

Evidence:

Waymo's official operational data shows that as of September 2025, its rider-only driverless mileage had reached 127 million miles; compared to human driving in the cities it operates in, serious injuries were reduced by approximately 90%, accidents involving injuries by approximately 81%, and accidents involving pedestrian injuries by approximately 92%.

This indicates that autonomous driving, at least under certain conditions, can indeed improve overall safety and well-being.

Autonomous driving is useful, especially if it can reduce harm and improve mobility.

However, its current use remains morally problematic because:

- benefits and risks are unevenly distributed: Companies gain profit and data. Users gain convenience. But pedestrians, cyclists, and other drivers may bear risks they never chose.
- responsibility is often unclear,
- sensitive data can be misused,
- the public has not fully agreed to these risks.

Other potential problems:

Supervision problem: Tesla’s official support page says that “FSD (Supervised) requires active driver supervision and does not make the vehicle autonomous.” Tesla also states that the driver remains responsible for safe operation and even for traffic violations while using the feature.

→ So the problem is not just whether autonomous driving helps someone. The problem is who gets the benefits, who carries the burden, and who absorbs the external risk.

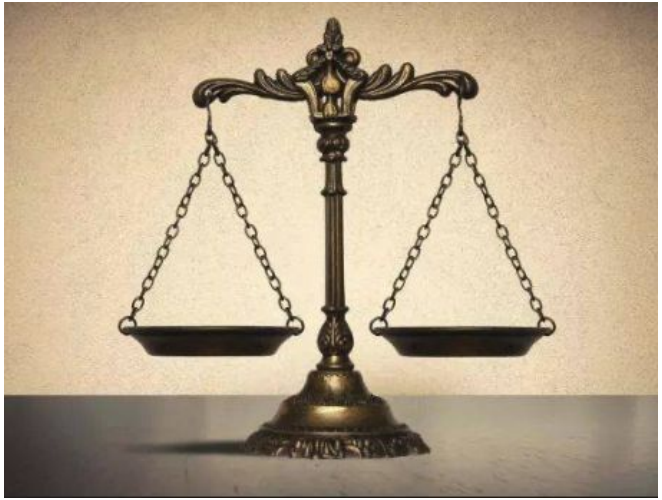
My thoughts:

Egoism can accelerate technological development, but it cannot completely solve the additional problems brought about by its advancement. We need to rationally utilize other philosophical ideas to guide our lives.

Egoism can bring us benefits. But let's not sacrifice other human qualities for personal interests: compassion, kindness, and selflessness.

Utilitarianism

“Greatest happiness for the greatest number."



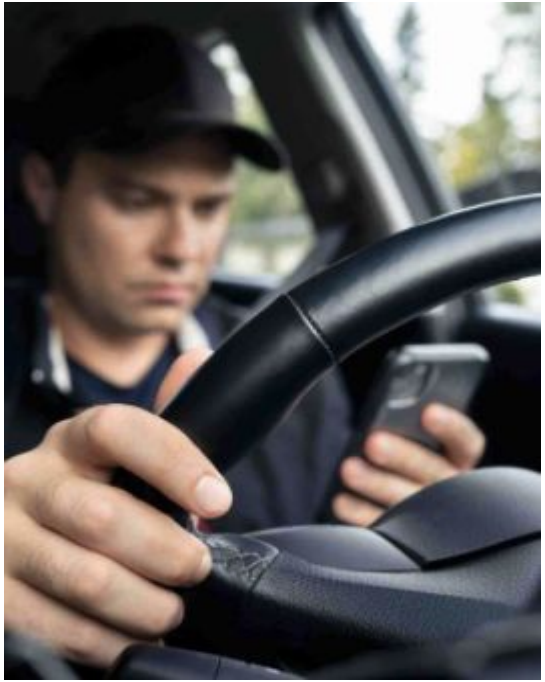
"Actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness."

— John Stuart Mill

Why We Need it ?

40,000+

94%



$190 Billion

Mobility Equality: Restoring Basic Rights

61 Million disabilities &
1.3 Million Blinders

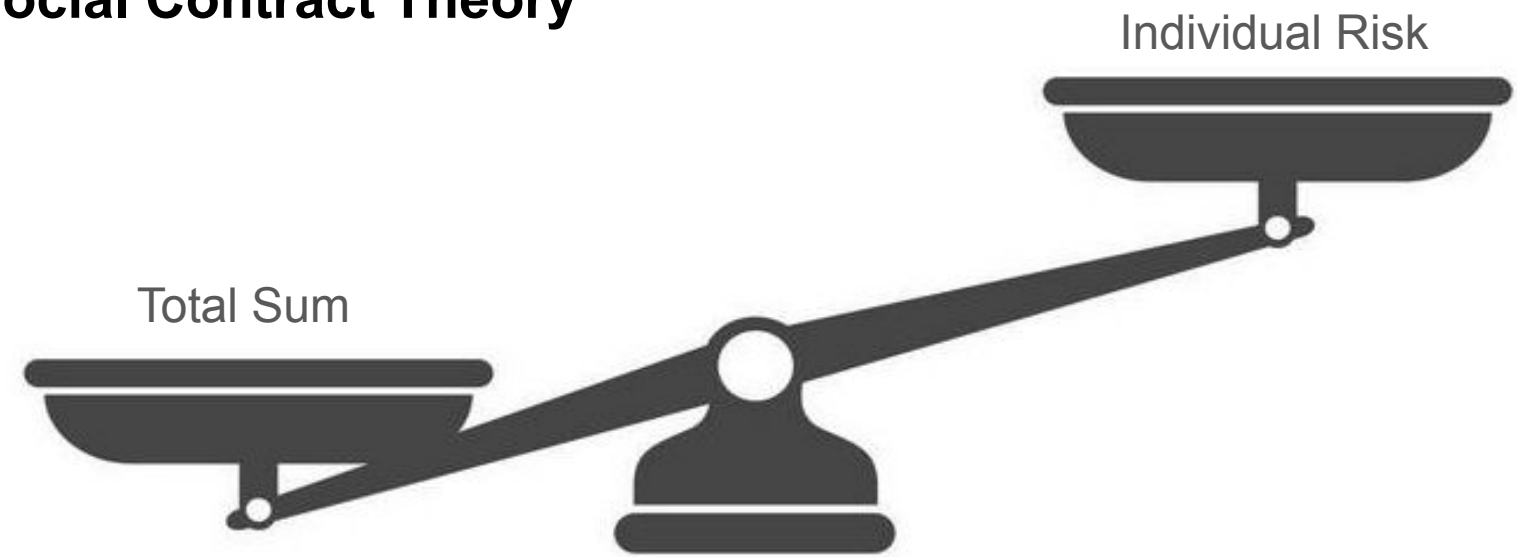
Smart audio & honk features

The Blind Spot

How to deploy fairly?

Social Contract Theory

"scapegoat objection"



Social contract

It needs to include all people affected by the rules.

It needs to include all people affected by the rules.

Manufacturers

It needs to include all people affected by the rules.

Manufacturers

Users

It needs to include all people affected by the rules.

Manufacturers

Users

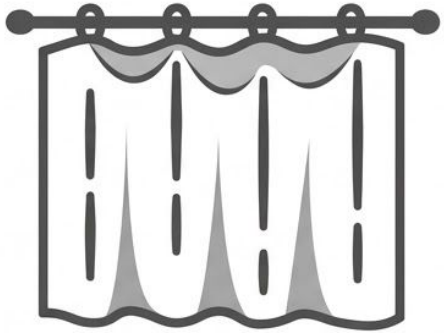
Third parties involved in traffic

rawls’s veil of ignorance

Veil Of Ignorance

Decision-maker

Members of society



Veil -Hiding

Personal interest or characteristics

Financial, monetary, or any policy- related decisions

- made without bias

Third parties involved in traffic

Third parties involved in traffic

- No money made
- No convenience enjoyed
- **Only risk**

If auto driving cars can consistently **not increase** risk in **all conditions:**

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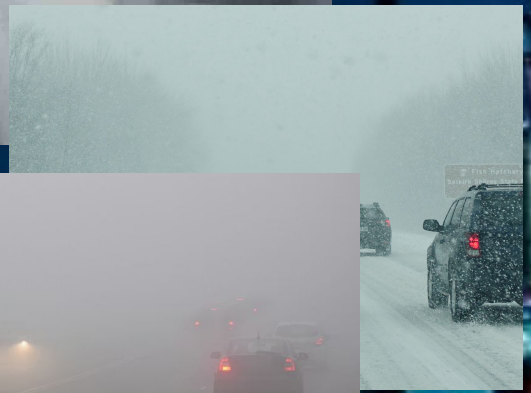
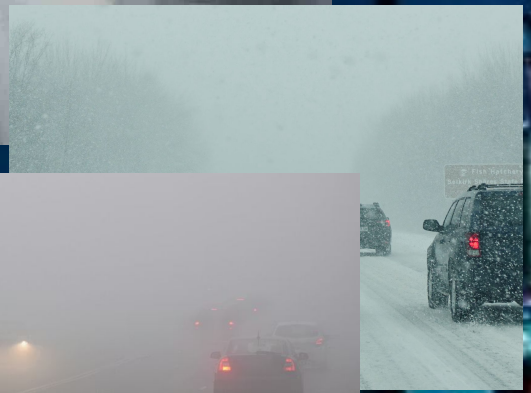


If auto driving cars can consistently **not increase** risk in **all conditions:**



If auto driving cars can consistently **not increase** risk in **all conditions:**

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BEST AUTO DRIVING SYSTEM
OF THE YEAR

But it can’t, not yet at least

I go to work by bike in the morning and returns home by bike in the evening

- Doesn’t earn money from it
- No convenience gain
- Happens to only travel in the time that the risk is maximized

Acceptable under fair conditions

We got data about safety easily from manufacturer’s advertisement.

We got data about risk from research paper.

Who read random research paper for fun?

Cell

nature

Science

AAAS

The NEW ENGLAND JOURNAL of MEDICINE

THE LANCET

thebmj

JAMA

Autopilot Is
Scary Good

Autopilot Is
Scary Good

nature chemistry
Carbenes take on silicon
nature
nature materials
Topological semimetals
nature
CHARACTER BUILDING
nature climate change
nature biotechnology
nature materials
nature chemi
Code of conduction

Manufacturers:

- Ton of data, know a lot about risk issue
- Only advertise their **overall** safety
- Doesn’t talk about high risk in special scenarios

Public

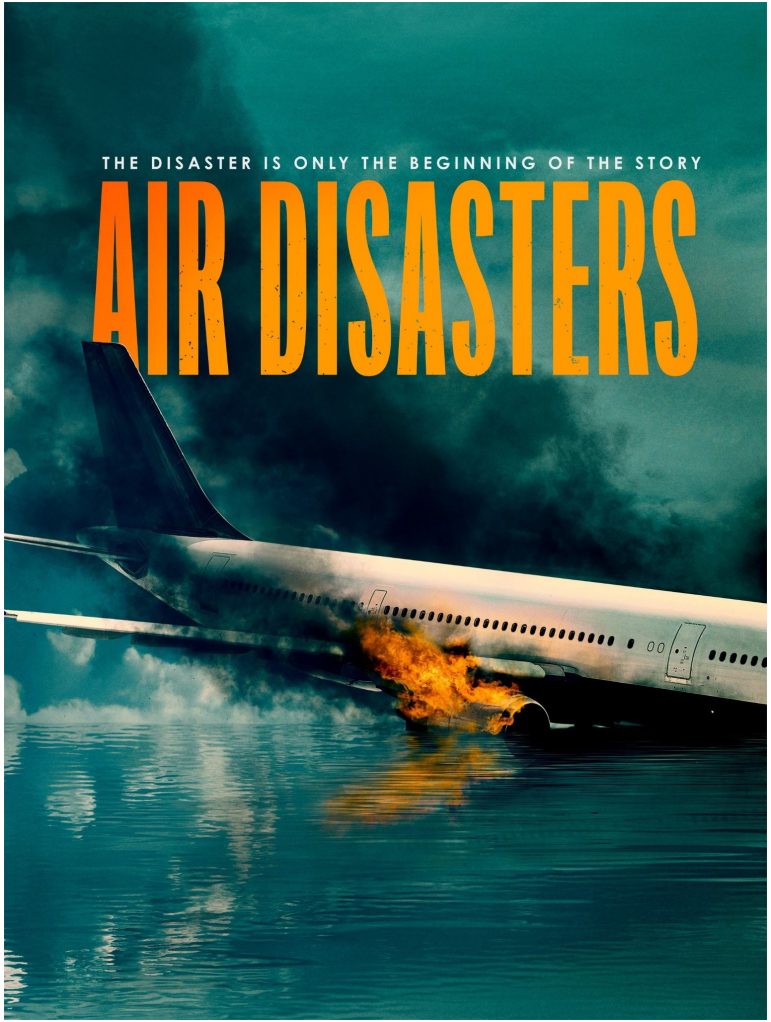
- Much easier to learn about safety, not risk
- This may lead to misjudgment.

Acceptable under fair conditions

But we can’t give up on it neither.
How to make it justifiable?

- Self-assessment on technical issues
- Very few accident will be investigated
- User responsible for supervising driving safety
- Complex accident claims process

2025 Tesla Model 3 Crash on FSD 13.2.8
February 27, 2025



Aviation industry

- Strict FAA safety certification
- Independent federal agency responsible for incident investigation
- Mandatory corrective action for safety risks
- Strict liability for damages, and no need to prove airline negligence

Do not make third parties face risk OR with no compensation.

- Better safer in all conditions
- Strict regulation
- Make compensation to people going to face higher risk.
  - Additional protection for third parties
  - Remove availability in higher-risk conditions
  - Manufacturers cover compensation liabilities.
- Disclose risks more honestly

Quick summarize for the section

- Social contract theory can:
  - Accept the social value of autonomous driving created
  - Prevent individuals from being treated as sacrifices for that value
- Current deployment practices is unacceptable:
  - **Not because** benefits and risks are distributed unfairly
  - Some third parties **are being** being treated as sacrifices
  - Public are not able to make decisions under fair conditions
- To become acceptable, autonomous driving deployment must:
  - Better safiey in all conditions
  - Provide more benefit to third parties
  - Disclose risks more honestly

Conclusion

In conclusion, from the perspectives of egoism and utilitarianism, people have ample reason to accept autonomous driving technology; while social contract theory further points out that this technology only has true ethical legitimacy when the risks and benefits can be distributed more fairly.

Achieving such fairness and democratic legitimacy requires systems based on consensus and decentralized governance, where decisions are not controlled by a small number of actors but emerge from broader social participation.

Course Reflection

Philosophy is not only about finding answers, but about providing a way to understand the world. Many things that once confused or even frustrated me can now be examined through different philosophical perspectives. These frameworks offer a logically coherent way to interpret complex issues.